

Vision Cone

Explore probable, plausible and preferable futures

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

The Vision Cone (futures cone) projects forward from the present into widening bands of **probable**, **plausible**, **possible** and **preferable** futures. It helps teams distinguish the future they expect from the one they want, and design toward the latter.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Adapted from futures studies (Hancock and Bezold, 1994; Voros, 2003) into design foresight practice.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Teams collapse many possible futures into a single default forecast. The cone reopens the space and makes 'preferable' an explicit design target.

FIGURE 1 · FUTURES CONE

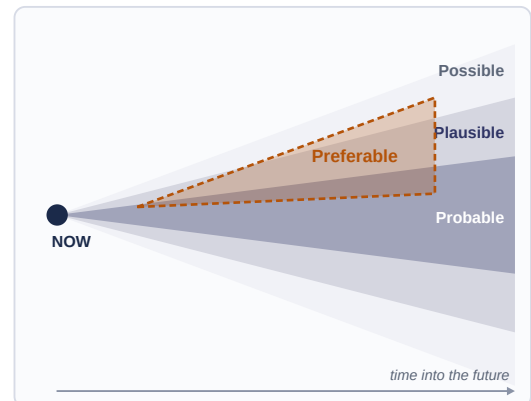


Figure 1. From the present, futures widen from probable to plausible to possible; the team designs toward the preferable.

HOW IT IS USED

From today, map plausible trajectories, mark the preferable future, and back-cast the steps and design moves needed to steer toward it.

WHEN IT IS USED

Visioning and longer-horizon innovation, and when setting a north star for a project.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Strategists, innovation leads and design-foresight practitioners.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It gives design an explicit **normative** dimension — not just predicting the future but choosing and building toward a preferred one.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Trend Analysis *Slibrary 5*

Context Mapping *Slibrary 6*

Define Success *Slibrary 10*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Voros, J. (2003) 'A generic foresight process framework', *Foresight*, 5(3), pp. 10–21.

Hancock, T. and Bezold, C. (1994) 'Possible futures, preferable futures', *Healthcare Forum Journal*, 37(2), pp. 23–29.